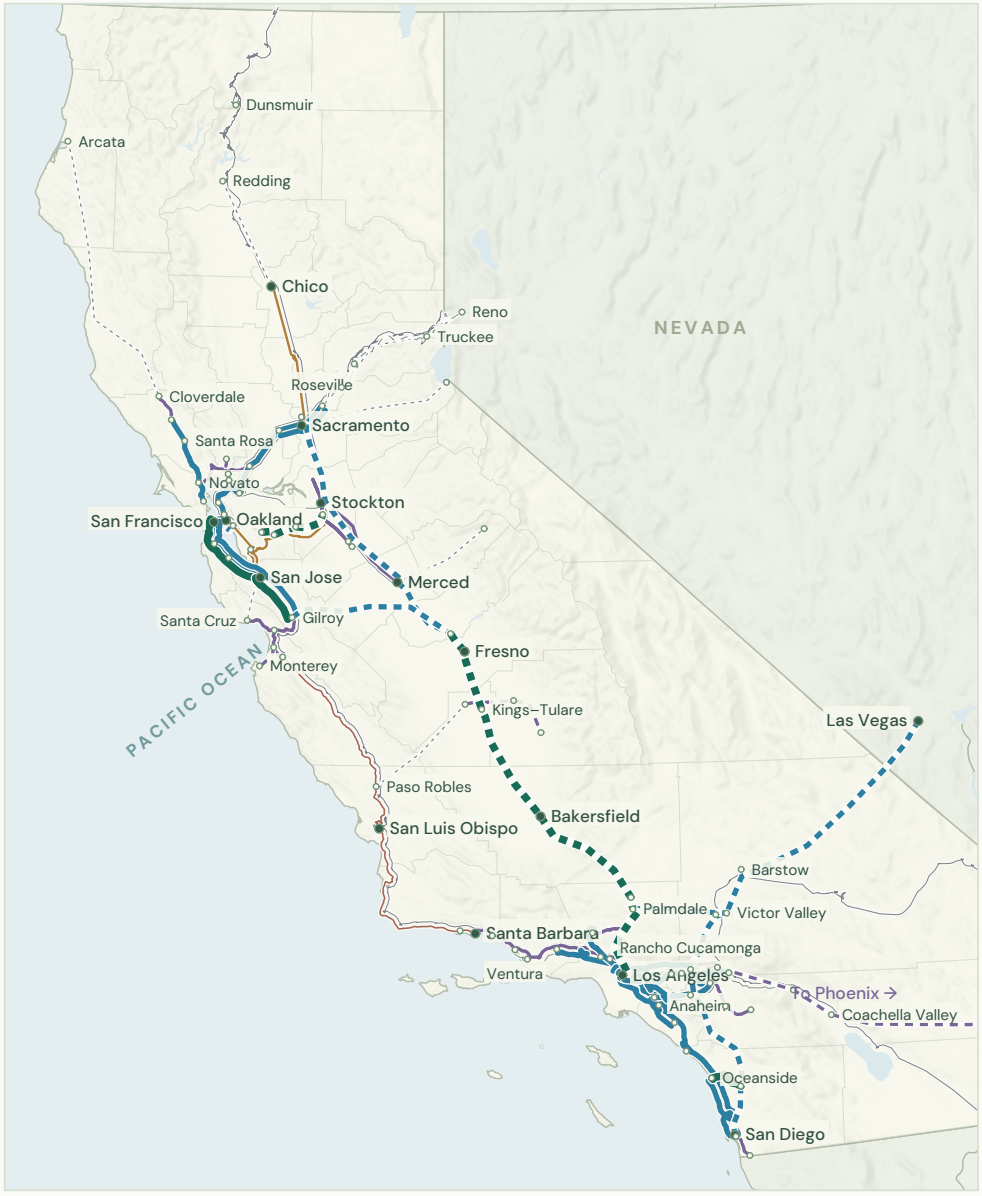
READING THE STATEWIDE VISION

Reading the 2050 network.

High-speed rail would connect regions, with conventional trains and buses serving other journeys. The proposed network depends on the connections between them.



≤15 min · 30 min · 60 min · 120 min · 240 min · Other

Timed buses · no numeric frequency specified

Long-distance Amtrak · 2024 inventory, not 2050 targets

THE 2050 PROPOSAL

30–60

minutes

Typical service goal across most of the state. Not every corridor; not an every-stop guarantee.

Plan p. 18

1,500

miles of overhead power

Envisioned by 2050 across the busiest and high-speed segments.

Plan p. 5

$307B

The plan's capital-program headline. **Not money already secured.**

Plan pp. 50–51

VISION ≠ TIMETABLE

These are 2024 planning targets, not live service, current project status or guaranteed opening dates.

Thicker numeric bands = more frequent. Fine Other lines are unquantified. Dotted gray = bus. Dashed = conceptual/generalized; solid = mapped rail, not funding. Selected hubs; urban transit summarized in the atlas.

SELECTED SERVICE GOALS, BY PLANNING HORIZON

How often would trains run?

Selected service goals—not booked train paths or a passenger timetable. The atlas has 70 goal layers plus four gray long-distance Amtrak routes from the 2024 inventory.

CORRIDOR / SERVICE	2028	2034	2050 VISION
Sacramento–Oakland	60 min	60 min	30 min
Sacramento–Roseville	1 daily RT	240 min	30 min
San Francisco–San Jose regional	≤15 min	≤15 min	≤15 min
Sacramento–Merced conventional	Growing	60 min combined	60 min regional
Merced–Bakersfield HSR	—	60 min	30 branch; ≤15 trunk[1]
Gilroy–Salinas intercity	Limited	Growth	60 min
Salinas–SLO state-service layer[2]	Timed bus	Timed bus	240 min
San Luis Obispo–Santa Barbara	240 min	240 min	240 min
Santa Barbara–Los Angeles	120 min	120 min	60 min* combined
Los Angeles–San Diego intercity	60 min	60 min	30 min
Lancaster–Santa Clarita regional	60 min	60 min	60 min
Santa Clarita–Los Angeles regional	30 min	30 min	30 min
Las Vegas–Rancho Cucamonga	60 min	60 min	30 min
Sacramento–Chico regional	Timed bus	Timed bus	120 min
Novato–Suisun/Fairfield regional	Timed bus	Timed bus	≤60 min
Healdsburg–Cloverdale regional	—	60 min	60 min

[2] Existing rail is not absent: the plan inventories a daily Coast Starlight round trip through Salinas–SLO and the Bay Area. It is separate from these future service goals. [Appendix 3.1, PDF p. 24]

[1] The long-term map shows a 30-minute Merced–Madera branch and a ≤15-minute combined HSR trunk south of Madera. This is not ≤15-minute service between every pair of stations.

* Santa Barbara–LA: Table 1 says coordinated hourly service; p. 34's narrative says combined half-hourly. This briefing uses the table's 60-minute value and flags the disagreement. RT = round trip.

REPEATING DOES NOT MEAN 24/7

A 30-minute target means two departures per hour in a uniform pattern. It does not specify operating span, peak overlays or every stopping pattern.

DO NOT ADD OVERLAPPING LINES

Two service layers in one corridor do not automatically create evenly spaced departures. Timetables and transfers must be designed together.

Sources: service tables pp. 37–38; regional maps pp. 30–36; network principles pp. 15–18

INFRASTRUCTURE AND THE SERVICE IT SUPPORTS

Projects and their connections.

These six examples show how individual projects affect journeys across the network. Costs are the 2024 appendix estimates, not current appropriations or remaining funding gaps.

1 Stockton crossing

$301.6M · 2028

Appendix PDF p. 6

Separating the UP–BNSF crossing would reduce conflicts between freight and passenger trains. **Ask:** which services does the design accommodate, and how would the available train paths and reliability change?

2 Merced interchange

$320M · 2034

Appendix PDF p. 10

Passengers from Sacramento and the Bay Area would change here for the initial high-speed line. **Ask:** how far will they walk, how long will they wait, and what happens when an arriving train is late?

3 Initial high-speed line

$33.8B · 2034

Appendix PDF p. 10

The mid-term plan proposes hourly Merced–Bakersfield trains. **Ask:** when will power, signaling, trains, testing, maintenance and connecting services be ready, alongside the track and structures?

5 Across the Bay

$57B · 2050

Appendix PDF p. 12

A second Bay crossing is part of a $57B corridor package that includes Carquinez capacity, electrification and shoreline protection. **Ask:** what could run at each stage, and who is responsible for the connections between projects?

6 LA Union Station

$1.6B · 2034

Appendix PDF p. 11

Through tracks would let trains continue south without reversing at Union Station. **Ask:** which routes would run through, which platforms and trains would they use, and what other corridor work would be needed?

7 San Clemente coast

$313.2M · 2028

Appendix PDF p. 6

Erosion and unstable slopes can interrupt the LA–San Diego railway. **Ask:** what protection is needed now, which longer-term alternatives are being studied, and how do they compare on outages and community and environmental effects?

Do not add these figures to estimate a funding gap: package and component costs can overlap. The interactive atlas includes 25 delivery priorities and a searchable 180-entry capital, grade-separation and fleet register. These selected projects are not the full capital program.

QUESTIONS FOR PUBLIC DECISION-MAKERS

Questions for elected officials.

These suggested questions draw on the plan; they are not quoted Caltrans recommendations. They concern the timetable, the resources to operate it, and the connections between projects.

2028

COMMITTED PROJECTS

The near-term program focuses on projects described as funded or committed in the 2024 plan. Check their current status separately.

2034

INITIAL HSR CONNECTIONS

The mid-term program includes the initial high-speed line and related connections, with funding and delivery decisions still to resolve.

2050

LONGER-TERM PLANNING

Further extensions and capacity need service studies, alternatives, environmental review, railroad agreements and funding.

2024 funding description: near term funded/committed; mid term funded or with a funding path; much long-term funding unidentified. Horizons are not guaranteed opening dates. Verify current commitments separately.

SIX QUESTIONS FOR PROJECT REVIEW

01 Which timetable is it designed for?

State & regional boards: ask for the service pattern, connections and reliability standard the design is intended to support.

02 Who will fund the service?

State & operators: identify the ongoing costs of trains, crews, power and maintenance, and who will cover them.

03 What else needs to be ready?

State & regional boards: identify the connecting projects, shared decisions and agency responsible for each.

04 Has the railroad agreed?

State, operators & hosts: confirm how train paths, dispatching and maintenance would be arranged on shared tracks.

05 How will the line remain usable?

All levels: distinguish emergency protection from long-term adaptation, and compare the effects of alternatives.

06 How will people reach the station?

Cities & counties: consider housing, bus connections, accessible walking routes and displacement around stations.

OPERATIONS AND MAINTENANCE

The plan models **$2.4B/year** for operations and maintenance of the proposed system. These recurring costs need a funding arrangement alongside the capital program. [Plan p. 51]

READ THIS BRIEFING RESPONSIBLY

Geography: California Albers; Caltrans rail GIS. Dashed routes are conceptual/generalized connections, not approved engineering. Hubs are selected anchors; urban transit is summarized. Gray Amtrak routes show the 2024 inventory, not future service goals (Appendix 3.1).

Evidence: December 2024 main plan (released January 2025), pp. 15–38 and 50–59; Appendices 2.1–2.3 and 3.1. No later project-status updates are blended in. Main plan capital headline: $307B; rounded appendix summary: ~$307.7B. This is an independent visualization, not Caltrans endorsement.

Official plan Official appendices

Companion: California-Rail-Atlas.html · Prepared October 2026